

Case Study: Motorica AG, The Culture Behind the Conflict

Opening

At the end of an Elysion brand review, Jonas Weber noticed that the most important signals were not in the official minutes. The creative director had praised the campaign film. The regional sales representative had nodded. The digital analyst had stayed silent after her first comment was corrected by a senior brand manager. When the meeting ended, three younger employees gathered in the corridor and continued the debate away from the conference table.

Jonas was Head of Marketing Europe at Motorica AG, a German car manufacturer known for premium vehicles, engineering precision, and carefully controlled brand communication. The company was preparing the European launch of Elysion, a new electric SUV with DriveSphere, an AI based cockpit service. The formal launch process assigned Brand Strategy, Digital Growth, and Product Marketing clear responsibilities. Yet the conflict between Brand Strategy and Digital Growth could not be explained only by formal task division.

Jonas began to suspect that the conflict was reinforced by Motorica's culture. Officially, the company described itself as innovative, customer-centered, and digitally ambitious. Informally, employees often spoke about "protecting the badge," "not experimenting with the brand," and "earning the right to speak." Jonas had to understand how these cultural patterns shaped the conflict before he could intervene.

Cultural background

Motorica's headquarters communicated tradition and precision. The entrance hall displayed historic vehicles, motorsport awards, and early design sketches from iconic models. Brand Strategy occupied offices close to the executive floor and often hosted agency presentations in rooms named after classic vehicles. Digital Growth worked in a more flexible project space near Customer Analytics and E-Commerce. Its walls showed campaign dashboards, funnel diagrams, and A/B test results.

Officially, these spaces were simply practical arrangements. Informally, they marked different status orders. Senior brand managers were seen as guardians of Motorica's long-term reputation. Digital specialists were admired for speed and data competence, but some employees described them as "campaign optimizers" rather than "brand people." Tobias Neumann, Head of Digital Growth, once joked that his team was invited to the launch "when the story was finished and the click-through rate was disappointing." Anna Klein, Head of Brand Strategy, said in a separate conversation: "A premium brand cannot be built by chasing the fastest signal."

Several stories circulated in the department. Brand managers often mentioned the "2012 discount mistake," when a price-oriented campaign for a compact model improved short-term leads but was later blamed for weakening residual values and dealer confidence. Digital Growth employees told a different story: during the 2023 hybrid model launch, early search data revealed customer anxiety about battery warranties, but the insight was reportedly ignored until dealers complained. Both stories were used as warnings. One warned against uncontrolled experimentation. The other warned against ignoring market signals.

Norms and assumptions

Jonas saw that many behaviors followed unwritten rules. Campaign proposals were expected to look complete before senior meetings. Strong disagreement in front of the agency was considered unprofessional. Junior employees rarely challenged senior brand judgments directly. At the same time, digital employees were expected to prove their relevance with measurable results and rapid iterations. These expectations produced different standards of legitimacy. Brand arguments sounded legitimate when they referred to heritage, coherence, and reputation. Digital arguments sounded legitimate when they referred to data, conversion, and responsiveness.

The cultural tension affected the Elysion launch. Brand Strategy assumed that an electric SUV needed emotional reassurance because Motorica customers might doubt whether electric mobility could still feel premium. Digital Growth assumed that prospective customers were already comparing software features, charging information, and real usage costs. Both assumptions were plausible. The problem was that the organization made one assumption easier to express in senior settings than the other.

The culture also shaped how conflict was expressed. Open disagreement with senior brand decisions was often interpreted as impatience or lack of respect for Motorica's history. Digital Growth employees therefore used dashboards, side conversations, and informal allies in Finance to strengthen their position. Brand Strategy employees interpreted this as political behavior and as evidence that Digital Growth did not

understand brand stewardship. The result was a cycle in which cultural norms against open confrontation pushed disagreement into indirect channels, which then made the conflict appear more political.

Exhibit 1. Additional cultural evidence from the marketing department

Type of evidence	Additional case evidence
Interview quote, senior brand manager	"A campaign can win clicks and still damage the brand. At Motorica, the badge has to outlive the quarter."
Interview quote, digital analyst	"We are asked for evidence, but when the evidence challenges the launch story, it suddenly becomes 'just a dashboard'."
Famous department story	Employees still refer to the "Geneva slide incident," when a junior marketer questioned a campaign headline during a board rehearsal. The comment was useful, but the person was later described as "not yet ready for executive rooms."
Artifact	The main brand conference room displays sketches of iconic Motorica models and a sign reading "Continuity creates trust."
Onboarding practice	New brand employees are guided through the heritage exhibition during their first week. New digital employees receive training on campaign tools and customer analytics, but rarely join the heritage tour.

Decision point

Jonas did not want to use "culture" as a vague explanation. He needed to identify which artifacts, values, assumptions, stories, and subcultures contributed to the conflict. He also had to decide whether Motorica's culture was mainly a barrier or whether parts of it could be used constructively. The company's commitment to quality, reputation, and engineering seriousness could protect the brand. The same commitment could also make the department slow to learn from new forms of digital evidence.

Your group task

You are advising Jonas Weber, Head of Marketing Europe at Motorica AG. Your group works on this case only. Prepare a 3 to 5 minute presentation with 2 to 3 slides. Use evidence from the case and end with a concrete recommendation that Jonas could implement before the next launch meeting.

1. Which artifacts, values, basic assumptions, and stories become visible in the case?
2. How do the subcultures of Brand Strategy and Digital Growth reinforce the conflict?
3. What should Jonas do to address the cultural roots of the conflict without undermining Motorica's legitimate concern for brand quality?

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop and refine this case.